Research on Athletics Participation

Published research compiled by the National Federation of State High School Associations (NFHS) reports that athletes have higher attendance, graduation rates, and GPAs than non-athletes, with larger differences for low-income students. AEI's April 2026 report (n=262,600) is the most recent study.

GRADUATION

99.4% vs 93.5%

Athlete vs. non-athlete graduation rate. Athletes ~**17× less likely to drop out**. Overton, North Carolina, 2001.

ATTENDANCE

−12.9 pp

Lower chronic absenteeism for athletes vs. non-athletes. Effect **~2× larger for low-income students**. AEI 2026 (n=262,600).

ACADEMIC PERFORMANCE

+0.81 GPA

Athlete GPA 2.98 vs. non-athlete 2.17 — **nearly a full letter grade**. Overton 2001 NC. Coe 2006: athletes ~10% better in core academics.

Six categories of evidence · 25 years of cited research

Outcome	Study (n, location, year)	Finding
Attendance	Malkus & Hollon · AEI · 2026 (n=262,600)	Athletes are **12.9 pp less likely to be chronically absent**. Effect ~2× larger for FRPM-eligible students.
Attendance	Overton · NC · 2001	Athletes miss **6.3 days/year** vs. **11.9 days** for non-athletes — nearly half as many absences.
Graduation	Overton · NC · 2001	Athlete graduation rate **99.4%** vs. non-athlete **93.5%**. Athlete dropout rate 0.6% vs. 10.32%.
Graduation / GPA	Lumpkin & Favor · KS · 2012 (n=~140,000)	Athletes graduate at higher rates and earn higher GPAs. **Students of color show much larger gains.**
College Attainment	Gardner · 2008 · Lipscomb · 2007	Activity participation positively associated with post-secondary attainment **2 and 8 years** after HS; **5% increase in BA-attainment**.
Discipline / Safety	Overton · NC · 2001	Discipline referral rate **33.3% (athletes)** vs. **41.8% (non-athletes)**.
School Safety	Sage · 2010 · Veliz & Shakib · 2012	Increased activity funding ↔ **decreased risk of physical assault** on educators. Higher sports participation ↔ **fewer serious crimes & suspensions**.
Mental Health & Substance Use	Taliaferro · 2008 · Harrison & Narayan · MN · 2003 (n=50,168)	Sports participation **significantly reduces risk of hopelessness and suicidal behaviors** in both males and females. **Significantly lower** alcohol, marijuana, and vandalism involvement.

★ **Findings by income. Everson & Millsap, 2005 (n = 480,000+ SAT scores)**: the impact of activity participation on academic outcomes is larger than the impact of family socioeconomic factors. **Marsh & Kleitman, 2002**: activities benefit socioeconomically disadvantaged students as much or more than advantaged students. **Lumpkin & Favor, 2012**: pay-to-play policies "discriminate against students who do not have the financial means."

Cost in context — NFHS national norm

District	Activities Budget	Total Budget	% of Budget
Chicago Public Schools	$17.6M	$4.93B	**<1%**
Los Angeles USD	$6.33M	$7.27B	**<1%**
Miami-Dade Schools	$17.2M	$3.70B	**<1%**
NFHS national norm: activities = 1-3% of total school budget			**1–3%**
GUHSD full Helix-stipend parity	**+$3.42M**	$343.6M GF	**~1.07%**

PRIMARY SOURCES

National Federation of State High School Associations, "The Case for High School Activities," nfhs.org (compiled body of cited research) · Overton, NC, 2001 · Born, MN, 2007 · Coe et al., 2006 · Fox et al., 2010 · Lumpkin & Favor, KS, 2012 (n=~140,000) · Lipscomb, 2007 · Gardner et al., 2008 · Peck et al., 2008 · Lutz et al., IA, 2009 · Rouse, NELS, 2012 · Harrison & Narayan, MN, 2003 (n=50,168) · Sage et al., 2010 · Veliz & Shakib, 2012 · Taliaferro et al., 2008 & 2010 · Marsh & Kleitman, 2002 · Everson & Millsap, 2005 (n=480,000+ SAT scores) · Malkus & Hollon, AEI, April 8 2026 (n=262,600 Indiana HS students). Full report & sources: jdavis-netizen.github.io/guhsd-athletics-funding-report